my eyes and ignored all the cheers and other sounds, and moved my arms and legs as fast as I could. Every bit of my energy went into pushing me ahead under the water's surface. Not even once did I raise my mouth out of the water to breathe until my hands finally felt the touch of marble, and it was then that I realized that I had reached the opposite side of the pool. The cheering reached my ears as I came out of the water, breathing heavily. After I wiped my eyes, I looked to my left and right and found that I was alone at the finishing point and the other candidates were still behind me. It had to be some kind of error, I thought at first. But when I saw Dada's friends making him turn around, pointing in my direction with a cheerful smile, I realized that I had won. Dada punched the air and jumped in excitement. Even though my start had been bad, I had managed to succeed, and it had been possible only because I had not lost my calm. Life had taught me what 'do or die' actually meant. I was going to lose, so I thought of doing so with dignity and channelled all my energy into my arms and legs. Instead of giving up, I ended up seizing the day. Papaji, Maa and Dada were so proud of me that day. I made it a point to remind myself of this incident if I was ever faced with such a situation again.

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When I opened my eyes, I took a deep breath and turned my aircraft back for another landing. Only this time, I did not let the CFI bother me with his shouting. To me, he did not even exist inside the aircraft in that moment. I only did what I had learnt from Babs Sir. The next two landings went well, without any hitches. As I taxied my aircraft on the tarmac after the check sortie was over, I could see Babs Sir, Anuradha and Supreet standing near the hangar. Whenever a cadet goes for their first solo flight, whether they have cleared it is denoted by the aircraft being turned off or not. If a cadet clears the solo, the aircraft will not be turned off; only the CFI will get out of the cockpit and the cadet will need to turn back and go for a solo flight. Babs Sir stood there, biting his nails, waiting to see whether my aircraft would turn off or not. When the aircraft came to a standstill, the canopy